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THE PROMISE OF REYKJAVIK

The Reykjavik meeting between President Reagan and General Secretary Gorbachev is now history. With the right kind of follow-through, it promises to be historic.

As with all meetings between high-level US and Soviet officials, the President approached the Reykjavik meeting prepared to raise our concerns in four areas: human rights, regional conflicts, bilateral matters, and arms control. All of these areas were addressed, and substantial progress was made on several issues. But the major focus of the meeting was on arms control.

In the arms control area, stunning progress was achieved. We may have laid the foundation for a sweeping US-Soviet agreements that will profoundly alter the strategic relationship and the basis for world peace.

The primary US goal for nuclear arms control has been to achieve deep and stabilizing reductions in strategic offensive arms, especially ballistic missiles, which present the greatest threat of surprise attack. In Reykjavik, the two leaders arrived at potential agreement on a 50% reduction in strategic offensive arms over five years, to be followed in the next five years by the complete elimination of all offensive ballistic missiles, regardless of range.

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In the area of intermediate-range nuclear forces (INF), our goal has been to achieve the deepest possible reductions in longer-range INF missiles on a worldwide basis. In Reykjavik,

two leaders reached potential agreement on the complete elimination of these missiles from Europe and the reduction of these missiles outside of Europe to 100 warheads on Soviet missiles in Asia, balanced by an equal number of warheads on US missiles on our territory. This represents a reduction of more than 90% from the current Soviet global level.

With regard to nuclear testing, we have sought to negotiate improved verification measures that would allow us to proceed toward ratification of the existing Threshold Test Ban Treaties and Peaceful Nuclear Explosion Treaties. We have told the Soviets that we are prepared, after this first step, to enter follow-on negotiations aimed at further limiting nuclear testing in parallel with reductions in nuclear arms. In Reykjavik, the two leaders reached potential agreement on this process.

And, of course, the President and General Secretary conducted an intense discussion of the issues of strategic defense. In this discussion, the President did his utmost to relieve Soviet concerns regarding the Strategic Defense Initiative, finally making an offer of historic proportions. The President said he would be willing to confine SDI activities within ABM Treaty limits for ten years, if the General Secretary would agree to eliminate offensive ballistic missiles by the end of that period. In response, Mr. Gorbachev

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demanded limits on SDI research activities that would go well beyond those of the ABM Treaty and have the effect of essentially killing the program. This the President could not accept.

Why can we not abide the end of SDI? Because SDI is the insurance policy we need to enforce future Soviet compliance with agreed reductions, and the Soviets have certainly given us reason to be concerned about their compliance. SDI has given the Soviets an incentive to negotiate reductions in offensive weapons and, in the future, the continuation of a robust research program would give them an incentive to comply with agreed reductions. Moreover, even in the context of the agreed elimination of ballistic missiles, we would still need some limited deployments of strategic defenses to protect us against cheaters or madmen.

We were thus disappointed in our attempts to complete the entire package at Reykjavik. We should keep this regret in context, however. The glass is not half-empty; in fact, it is almost completely full.

We accomplished a tremendous amount, more than anyone would have predicted a week ago, and there is no reason why any of this progress should be lost. We have made clear that the positions to which the two leaders agreed should stand, and Mr. Gorbachev has indicated likewise. The task before us is to consolidate the gains of Reykjavik and concentrate on the remaining obstacles to agreement, at the negotiations in Geneva and through other diplomatic channels.

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We are prepared to move forward; Mr. Gorbachev says he is as well. If so, with a concerted effort on both sides, the promise of the Reykjavik meeting can become the accomplishment of the Washington summit.

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